

Legal Ease

Core Functionalities Development Document

Legal practice management platform: from intake to file closing

Document type	Product development specification
Version	1.0 (Draft)
Status	For review

1. Overview

Legal Ease is a platform that helps law firms run each matter from first client contact to file closing in one system. It replaces scattered spreadsheets, email threads and separate tools with a single workflow that covers intake, conflict checks, engagement, matter setup, drafting, review, filing, billing and closing.

1.1 Objectives

- Reduce administrative time per matter through automation of repeated tasks.
- Prevent missed deadlines and limitation dates.
- Keep client data and privileged communications secure and auditable.
- Give partners clear visibility into workload, billing and matter status.

1.2 Target Users

Role	Primary needs
Partner / Attorney	Matter oversight, review and approval, billing visibility, deadlines
Associate / Paralegal	Drafting, research, document handling, time entry, task tracking
Admin / Office Manager	Intake, scheduling, invoicing, records management, user setup
Client	Secure document sharing, status updates, invoices and payments

2. Core Modules

The platform is organized into nine core modules that map to the firm workflow. Priority key: P1 = launch-critical, P2 = important, P3 = later.

Module	Purpose	Priority
Client and Matter Management	Central record of clients, contacts, matters, parties and key facts	P1
Conflict Checking	Screen new parties against existing clients and matters	P1
Engagement and Retainer	Generate and e-sign engagement letters, fee agreements, retainers	P1
Calendar and Deadlines	Court dates, limitation periods, reminders, task assignment	P1
Document Management and Drafting	Storage, versioning, templates, document assembly	P1
Review and Approval	Attorney review, comments, client sign-off, audit trail	P2
Time and Billing	Time tracking, invoices, trust accounting, payments	P1
Client Portal	Secure messaging, document exchange, status and invoices	P2

Module	Purpose	Priority
Reporting and Analytics	Dashboards for workload, revenue, matter aging	P2

3. Functional Requirements

3.1 Client and Matter Management

- Capture client details (individual or organization), contacts, related parties and opposing counsel.
- Create matters with type, practice area, responsible attorney, team, status and key dates.
- Configurable intake forms per practice area with required fields.
- Link matters to clients, documents, tasks, time entries and invoices.
- Full-text search across clients, matters and notes.

3.2 Conflict Checking

- Automatic search of new client and party names against all existing clients, parties and opposing parties.
- Fuzzy matching for name variants, aliases and misspellings.
- Conflict report with matches, reviewer sign-off and a stored decision record.
- Block matter opening until the check is cleared or waived by an authorized user.

3.3 Engagement and Retainer

- Engagement letter and fee agreement templates by matter type.
- Electronic signature with timestamped signed copy saved to the matter.
- Retainer request and payment tracking linked to the trust or operating account.
- Status tracking: draft, sent, signed, expired.

3.4 Calendar and Deadlines

- Shared firm calendar with matter-linked events and tasks.
- Deadline rules engine that calculates dates from a trigger event (for example, filing date plus response period), configurable by jurisdiction.
- Multi-level reminders by email and in-app notification.
- Two-way sync with Google and Outlook calendars.
- Escalation to a supervising attorney when a critical deadline is at risk.

3.5 Document Management and Drafting

- Matter-based folder structure with version history and check-in/check-out.
- Template library with merge fields drawn from matter and client data.
- Document assembly: generate a draft from a template in one action.
- Support for Word, PDF and common image formats; OCR for scanned files.
- Granular permissions and ethical walls for restricted matters.

3.6 Review and Approval

- Assign documents to reviewers with due dates.
- Inline comments, tracked changes and side-by-side version comparison.
- Approval states: draft, in review, approved, sent to client, filed.
- Client sign-off through the portal with an audit record.

3.7 Time and Billing

- Timers and manual time entry with activity codes, tied to matters.
- Billing arrangements: hourly, flat fee, contingency and retainer.
- Invoice generation on a schedule with review before sending.
- Trust account ledger with three-way reconciliation support.
- Online payments (card and bank transfer) and automated payment reminders.

3.8 Client Portal

- Secure login with multi-factor authentication.
- Encrypted messaging and document exchange scoped to the client's matters.
- Matter status view, upcoming dates and invoice history.
- Task requests to clients, such as uploading documents or completing forms.

3.9 Reporting and Analytics

- Dashboards for open matters, deadlines due, billable hours, collections and aging receivables.
- Filters by attorney, practice area, client and date range.
- Scheduled and on-demand exports to PDF and CSV.

4. Non-Functional Requirements

Area	Requirement
Security	Encryption in transit (TLS) and at rest, MFA, role-based access control, full audit logging
Privacy and compliance	Support for attorney-client privilege, data residency options, GDPR and applicable bar and trust accounting rules
Performance	Page loads under 2 seconds for typical views; search results under 3 seconds
Availability	Target 99.9% uptime with daily backups and tested recovery
Scalability	Support firms from solo practitioners to several hundred users
Usability	Responsive web app, accessible to WCAG 2.1 AA, mobile-friendly for time entry and calendar
Integrations	Email, calendar, e-signature, payment gateway, accounting software, cloud storage

5. Suggested Architecture

A modular web application with a clear separation between client interface, application services and data storage. The stack below is a recommendation and can be adjusted to team skills.

Layer	Suggested approach
Frontend	React single-page app with a component library; responsive design
Backend	REST or GraphQL API in Node.js or Python; service modules per core module
Database	PostgreSQL for relational data; full-text search index for documents and matters
File storage	Encrypted object storage with virus scanning and versioning
Background jobs	Queue for reminders, invoice runs, OCR and email sync
Auth	OAuth 2.0 / OpenID Connect, MFA, role-based permissions
Hosting	Cloud deployment with separate staging and production, CI/CD pipeline

5.1 Key Data Entities

Client, Contact, Matter, Party, Task, Event, Deadline Rule, Document, Document Version, Template, Time Entry, Invoice, Payment, Trust Transaction, User, Role, Audit Log.

6. Development Roadmap

Phase	Scope	Outcome
Phase 1: Foundation	Users and roles, client and matter records, intake forms, conflict checking, audit logging	Firms can open and manage matters securely
Phase 2: Workflow	Engagement and e-signature, calendar and deadlines, document management and templates	Firms can run matters end to end
Phase 3: Money	Time tracking, invoicing, trust accounting, online payments	Firms can bill and collect in the platform
Phase 4: Collaboration	Review and approval, client portal, notifications	Clients and attorneys work in one place
Phase 5: Insight and scale	Reporting, integrations, e-filing connectors, mobile improvements	Firm-wide visibility and wider ecosystem

7. Risks and Mitigations

Risk	Mitigation
Jurisdiction-specific deadline rules are complex	Start with a small set of jurisdictions; make rules configurable; require attorney verification
Data breach or privilege exposure	Encryption, MFA, ethical walls, regular security testing and audit logs
Trust accounting errors	Strict validation, reconciliation reports, review by accounting specialists
Low user adoption	Simple intake and time entry, data import tools, onboarding and training
Scope growth	Priority tiers (P1 to P3) and phased releases

8. Acceptance Criteria (Summary)

- A new matter cannot be opened until conflict checking is cleared or waived.
- Every deadline generates reminders and appears on the responsible user's calendar.
- Every document change is versioned and recorded in the audit log.
- Invoices reconcile to time entries, and trust ledger balances match by client.
- Clients can only see matters and documents shared with them.

Note: This is a draft specification. Legal and compliance requirements vary by jurisdiction and should be confirmed with qualified counsel before build.